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Data centers' air pollution associated with lung issues: Report

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COLUMBUS, Ohio ([WCMH](#)) — [Emissions from data centers](#) can cause breathing issues and premature deaths for those living nearby, according to a new report.

The report was compiled by Community & Environmental Defense Services (CEDS) founder and president Richard Klein, who has been working in development-related concerns for 40 years. Klein found that a single [data center](#) could pose negative health risks for people living at least 0.6 miles away, sometimes further.

Klein said risks increase when a home is near [multiple data centers](#).

A growing number of Americans in the central U.S. live near one or more data centers or will in the near future. [Data centers](#) are massive buildings that store computing equipment and support IT servers, data storage and networks.

The centers are necessary to support the digital infrastructure that modern society relies on. However, some people take issue with data center construction near their homes and schools, citing pollution and health concerns.

Klein said [air pollution](#) risks come from data centers emitting nitrogen dioxide and tiny, [inhalable particles](#) that can harm people's lungs. According to the National Institute of Health, the particles cause between 100,000 and 200,000 premature deaths each year.

Data centers require vast amounts of power, and the influx of the complexes has caused some people's energy bills to go up. With [rising electric costs](#) drawing public frustration, developers are beginning to pursue alternative power options, which can bring additional pollutants in turn.

The centers also cannot lose power without risking vast amounts of data, so they may rely on emergency backup generators. Many data centers use [diesel generators as backup power](#), which are particularly strong polluters.

Klein recommends that states require public health assessments for neighboring communities before a new complex is built.

Data centers and the controversy surrounding them came up during Tuesday night's [State of the Union](#) address. President Trump said he would press tech companies involved in artificial intelligence to pay higher electricity rates in areas where their data centers are located. The buildings tend to use large volumes of electricity, potentially increasing the cost of power to other consumers in the area.

The White House will host major tech companies involved in building out the centers for artificial intelligence on March 4 for them to [sign a pledge](#) to protect consumers from higher electricity prices.

The Associated Press contributed to this report.

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